The Sermon at Benares

The big idea

The Sermon at Benares tells how **Gautama Buddha** taught that **death is universal** and that grief should not make us selfish. Through the story of **Kisa Gotami**, it shows how wisdom helps us accept loss.

BUDDHA'S LIFE IN BRIEF

- Born a prince, **Siddhartha Gautama**, in northern India (about 563 BC).
- Lived a sheltered life as a prince and married a princess. At about **twenty-five** he saw a **sick man**, an **aged man**, a **funeral procession** and a **monk begging** for alms.
- Left his princely life to seek enlightenment; after seven years of wandering he sat under a **peepal tree** (later called the **Bodhi tree**, Tree of Wisdom) and was **enlightened** — he became **the Buddha, the Awakened** or Enlightened One.
- He preached his **first sermon at Benares** (Varanasi), the holiest bathing place on the Ganges.

The story of Kisa Gotami

1. Kisa Gotami's **only son** died. Mad with grief, she carried the body from house to house asking for **medicine** to bring him back to life.
2. People thought she had lost her senses. A man sent her to the **Buddha**.
3. The Buddha asked her to bring **a handful of mustard seed** from a house where **no one had lost a child, husband, parent or friend**.
4. At every house people gladly offered mustard seed but said they had lost someone: "the living are few, but the dead are many".

5. Tired and hopeless, she sat by the wayside and watched the lights of the city flicker and go out. She realised that **human life is like these lights** — it burns and is extinguished.
6. She understood that she had been **selfish** in her grief, since **death is common to all**.

The sermon's teachings

- The life of mortals is **troubled, brief and combined with pain**.
- Everyone who is born must die; just as ripe fruit falls early, mortals are always in danger of death.
- Like **earthen vessels made by a potter**, all lives end in being broken.
- Neither the young nor the old, the foolish nor the wise, can escape death.
- **Weeping and grieving bring no peace**; they only increase pain and harm the body. The wise do not grieve, knowing the terms of the world.
- **Whoever has overcome sorrow will become free from sorrow and be blessed.**

SIMILES IN THE SERMON

Ripe fruits falling, earthen vessels breaking, and city lights flickering out — all show that **death is inevitable**.

THE BUDDHA DID NOT REFUSE TO HELP

He did not trick Kisa Gotami cruelly; his request was a **lesson** to make her discover the truth herself.

Values and message

- Accept death as a natural part of life.

- Grief turned inward becomes selfishness; sharing others' sorrows brings peace.
- Teaching through experience is more powerful than lecturing.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did the Buddha ask for mustard seed? What did Kisa Gotami realise? What did the Buddha see that made him leave home? "Kisa Gotami's grief was selfish" — explain. What lesson does the sermon teach?

Quick recap

- Siddhartha → saw sickness, age, death, a monk → enlightenment under the Bodhi tree → first sermon at Benares.
- Kisa Gotami's dead son; mustard seed from a house untouched by death.
- City lights flickering = human lives.
- Death is universal; overcoming sorrow brings peace.

Practice questions

1. Where did the Buddha preach his first sermon?
   (a) Bodh Gaya (b) Benares (c) Lumbini (d) Kapilavastu
2. What sights made Siddhartha leave his princely life?
   (a) A war and a famine (b) A sick man, an aged man, a funeral and a begging monk (c) A flood and an earthquake (d) His father's death
3. What did the Buddha ask Kisa Gotami to bring?
   (a) A medicine from the forest (b) Water from the Ganges (c) Rice from a temple (d) A handful of mustard seed from a house where no one had died
4. What did the flickering city lights make Kisa Gotami realise?
   (a) Human lives are lit up and then extinguished (b) The night was dark (c) She was lost (d) The city was beautiful
5. According to the sermon, who escapes death?
   (a) The wise (b) The rich (c) The young (d) No one
6. The sermon compares mortals to
   (a) stars in the sky (b) rivers flowing to the sea (c) earthen vessels made by a potter (d) birds in a cage
7. What did Kisa Gotami understand after visiting the houses?
8. How did the Buddha help Kisa Gotami without giving her a lecture? What is the message of the sermon?

Answers: 1. b 2. b 3. d 4. a 5. d 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes